online, policing of social media will further restrict free speech and activism in Pakistan. These questions of freedom and rights are important as the powers of the security state are strengthened. However, for the participants in this study in 2015–16, the question of state censorship and the possibility that social media could be a space for promoting political activism were seldom mentioned. If anything, social media could promote political awareness but the extent to which that awareness translates into action is questionable.

Using social media in Pakistan

As with the participant quotes in the beginning of this chapter, the use of social media for participants in this study was similar to that identified by Khan and Nisbet (2016). In their study they point to the use of the internet for the purposes of 'email (91%), communicating on social networking sites (77%), reading international newspapers (68%), posting videos or video clips online (68%), downloading or listening to music or watching videos online (65%), and using internet telephony (63%)' (2016, p. 10). Social media as discussed in the present study was a space predominantly for connecting with friends and family. In relation to political activism, the narratives in this study highlight both the *potential* of social media as a source to promote political literacy, and its *limitation* in encouraging students to act on this literacy offline, in the 'real' world. Howard et al.'s (2016) 'slacktivism hypothesis' takes a new form among social media users in Pakistan. 'Slacktivism' draws on 'the supposition that if internet or social media use increases, civic engagement declines' (Howard et al. 2016, p. 56). Howard et al. challenge this hypothesis in their study of Mexico, but the participants in this research reaffirm it.

While students gave mixed responses to the question of activism on social media, often their responses were dependent on how they defined political activism as discussed in Chapter 2. Some participants at a private university in Karachi argued how social media was one form of activism '*It is about being vocal about your political ideology through social media, by attending rallies, vigils, vocally condemning something*' (Focus Group, Private University[11]). However, the problem was in participants differentiating between awareness and activism. For some '*putting up a comment over something political makes one politically active in my opinion*' (Student, Female, Karachi). With the sentencing of Taimoor Raza over a Facebook argument, or the arrest of bloggers, or attempts by the Pakistani state to gain the personal data of Facebook users – in other words,